SAP Fall 2026 Project

Naeem Bahemia, Naitik Rambhia, Sunay Konnur, Braden Parker, Andrew Morin



01 Squad Context

Newcastle Overview

12th

25/26 Premier League Finish

$150M

Starting Budget

~$721M

Squad Value

Start of 2026/27

13th

-3 GD

After 9 games



Newcastle United: An Overview

Manager: Matthias Jaissle

Al-Ahli 2025/26 – 3rd in Saudi Pro League
· 4th in xG | +46 goal difference
· 25 goals conceded | 17 clean sheets
· 4th in Possession Won Final 3rd

Tactical Identity
· Vertical, high-intensity gegenpressing
· Quick in-possession progression
· Recovering the ball high up the pitch

Newcastle Foundation
· 4th youngest squad in Premier League
· 8th in distance covered

Current Problems
· 18th in xG
· 18th in xGA
· 18th in Possession Won Final 3rd
· 17th in Big Chances Created



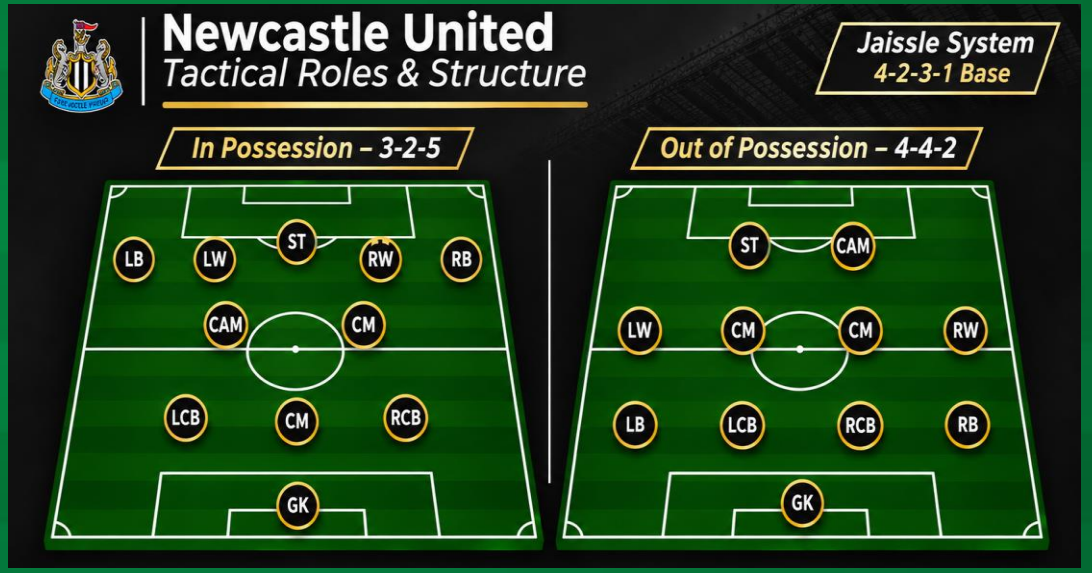
Role Overview

Key Notes

· Fullbacks provide width while wingers attack inside spaces

· One CM drops into buildup while the other supports the attack

· CAM joins the striker to initiate the press in a compact 4-4-2



Key Players

Nico Gonzalez - CM



· One of the most structurally important players in Newcastle's midfield
· Breaks lines through progressive passing and carries
· Connects Newcastle's build-up with its vertical attack
· Key to progressing possession through the first and second phases

Lewis Hall - LB



· Primary progressive outlet from the left side
· Provides ball carrying and creativity from deeper positions
· Comfortable advancing into higher areas during possession
· Young profile with significant room for development

Lukáš Horníček - GK



· 2nd in the Premier League with +4.1 goals prevented
· 31 saves, 3rd most among Premier League goalkeepers
· 3.44 saves per 90
· Has faced 17.1 xGOT, showing the volume and quality of shots Newcastle's defense has allowed
· Provides strong sweeping activity behind the defensive line

Recruitment Priorities

Chance Creation
- 18th in xG
- 17th in Big Chances Created
- Need creators from central and wide areas

High Press
- 18th in Possession Won Final 3rd
- Need players capable of sustaining Jaissle's pressing intensity

Progressive Width
- Fullbacks must provide width & creation in the in-possession structure
- Need attacking output and progression from both sides

Squad Depth
- Key roles lack stylistically similar replacements
- Clearest Example:
  - Nico Gonzalez & Lewis Hall lacked first-team depth behind them



02

Analysis

Data Analysis Pipeline

DATA SOURCES
Bzzorio API
Player-Match Statistics
Squad & Market Data

DATA PROCESSING
Clean & Standardize
Aggregate Match Data
Calculate Per-90 Metrics

PLAYER PROFILING
Positional Percentiles
Role-Specific Metrics
Age & Minute Filters

ROLE ANALYSIS
Positional Percentiles
Role-Specific Metrics
Age & Minute Filters

RECRUITMENT OUTPUT
Candidate Shortlists
Tactical Validation
Value Comparison

Analysis Plan

01

Define Tactical Roles & Identify Squad Needs

- Analyze squad and team performance
- Define positional weaknesses
- Translate Jaissle's system into player roles

02

Build Player Profiles

- Create per-90 player metrics
- Calculate positional percentiles
- Define role-specific performance profiles

03

Find Targets

- Filter players by role requirements
- Use KNN to identify similar profiles
- Rank players by tactical fit

04

Validate & Recruit

- Review tactical usage and heatmaps
- Consider age, physical profile, and development
- Compare performance against transfer cost
- Make final recruitment decision



Developing Jaissle & Role Fit Scores + KNN

· Converted Jaissle's tactics into **position-specific statistical profiles** using metrics tied to each role

· Standardized player performance using **league-wide percentiles**, allowing consistent comparisons across players and positions

· Weighted the most important attributes for each role to create **Jaissle Fit and Role Fit Scores** for recruitment

· Used **K-Nearest Neighbors (KNN)** to identify players with similar statistical profiles to key Newcastle players

· Combined similarity with **role-specific needs, defensive contribution, age, and transfer value** to find realistic recruitment targets

03 Notable Data-Driven Signings

Nikola Krstović — ST — $33m

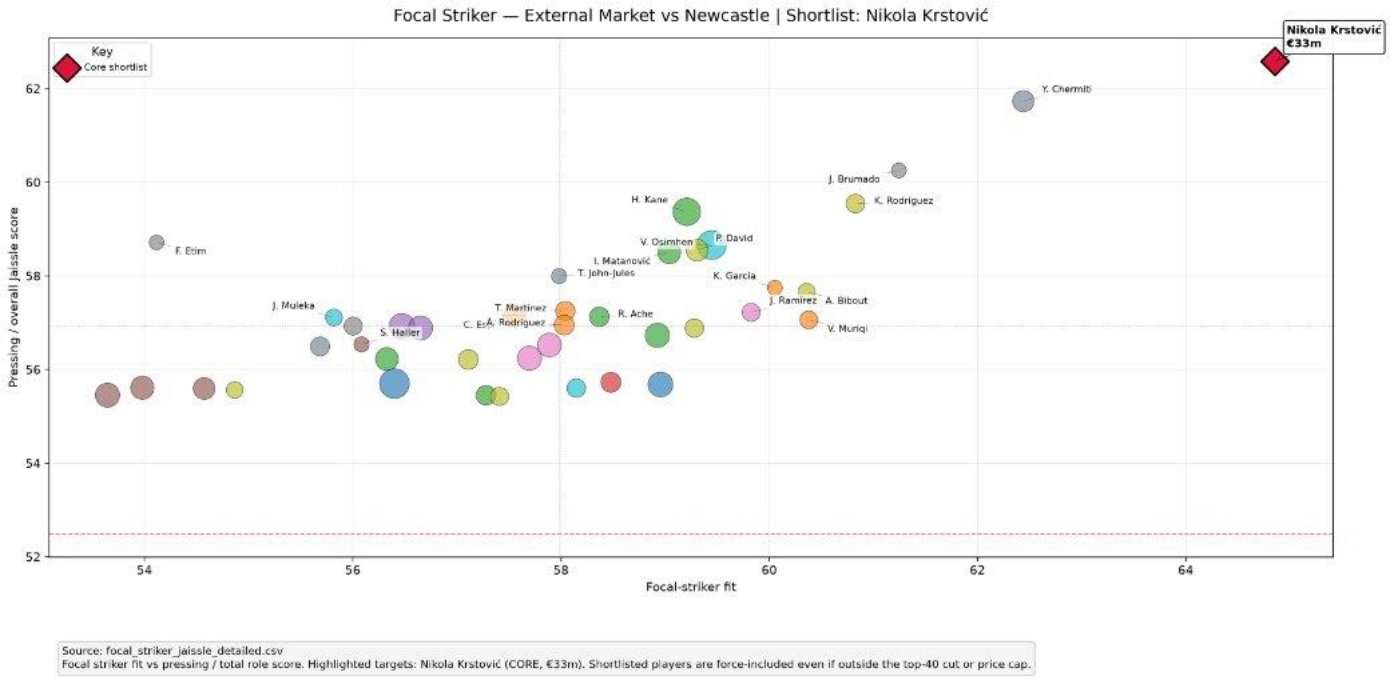


Why we want him:

- Biggest hole in the squad is still a true starting 9.
- Scores 62.58 in our focal striker model, about +14 over our current benchmark.
- Strong shot volume and goal threat.
- Gives us an actual focal point so Wissa can play more as a 10/second striker instead of being forced to lead the line.

- Role:
  - Starting striker.
  - Osula becomes depth/development instead of being asked to carry the position.

Striker Model Visualization



ST Role Fit + Jaissle Striker Score:

· 30% Focal-Striker Fit · 25% Box Threat · 20% Focal Presence · 15% Pressing Activity · 10% Link Play

Rayan Aït-Nouri — LB / LWB — $32.5m



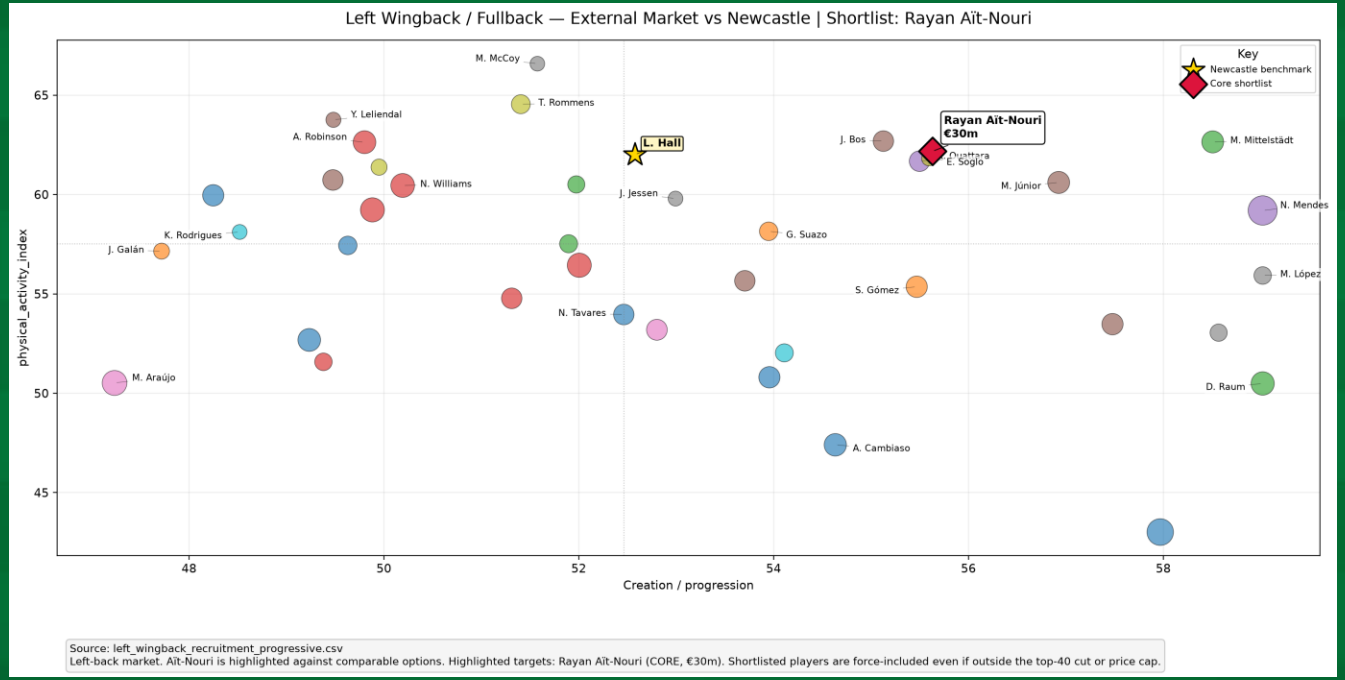
Why we want him

- Hall gives us the balanced option, but Aït-Nouri gives us the more aggressive/creative option.
- Lets us change the left side depending on opponent instead of asking Hall to do everything.

Role

- Rotation/competition with Hall.
- More attacking LB option.
- Burn can still cover LB when we want something more defensive.

LB Data Visualization



LB Role Fit + Jaissle Fullback Score:

· 40% Wingback Fit · 30% Attacking Creation · 30% Physical/Pressing Activity,

Darko Nejašmić — CDM — $3m



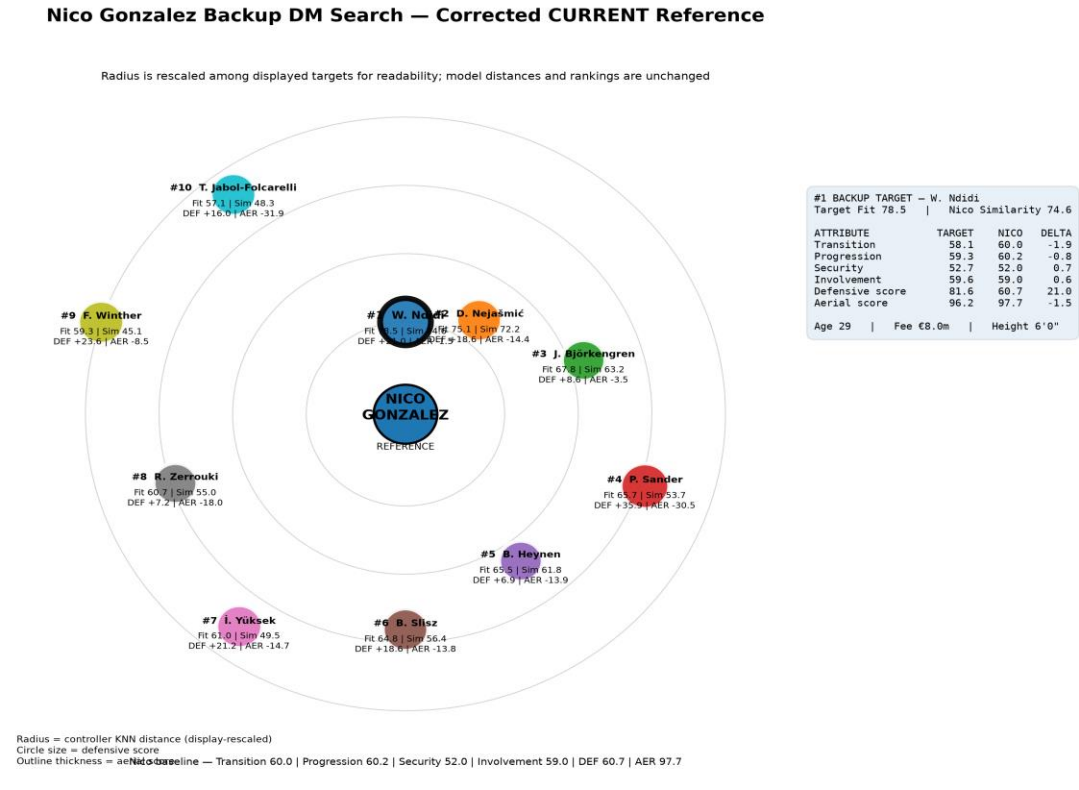
Why we want him:

- Gives us a low-cost backup for Nico without changing the midfield profile
- 72.24 Nico Similarity Index, second-best realistic backup in the model
- Extremely close stylistically in Deep Involvement (99.5% similarity) and Transition Protection (94.8%)
- Also maintains strong Possession Security similarity (83.2%), so he can still function as a controller rather than just a defensive midfielder
- Adds more defensive activity with 6.68 recoveries/90 and 1.76 tackles/90

Role:

- Backup holding midfielder / controller behind Nico González
- Provides a slightly more defensive option when protecting transitions or closing out matches
- Allows us to preserve the same midfield structure when Nico is rested or unavailable

CDM Data Visualization



Outgoing Players | +$113.5M

- Tino Livramento · **$50M** · LB/RB
  - Injury prone with high resale value
- Joe Willock · **$15M** · CAM
  - Limited role fit within the midfield structure
- Harvey Barnes · **$37.5M** · LW
  - High sale value, opening up minutes for a better winger
- Jacob Murphy · **$11M** · RW
  - Profit opportunity for greater right-side creation





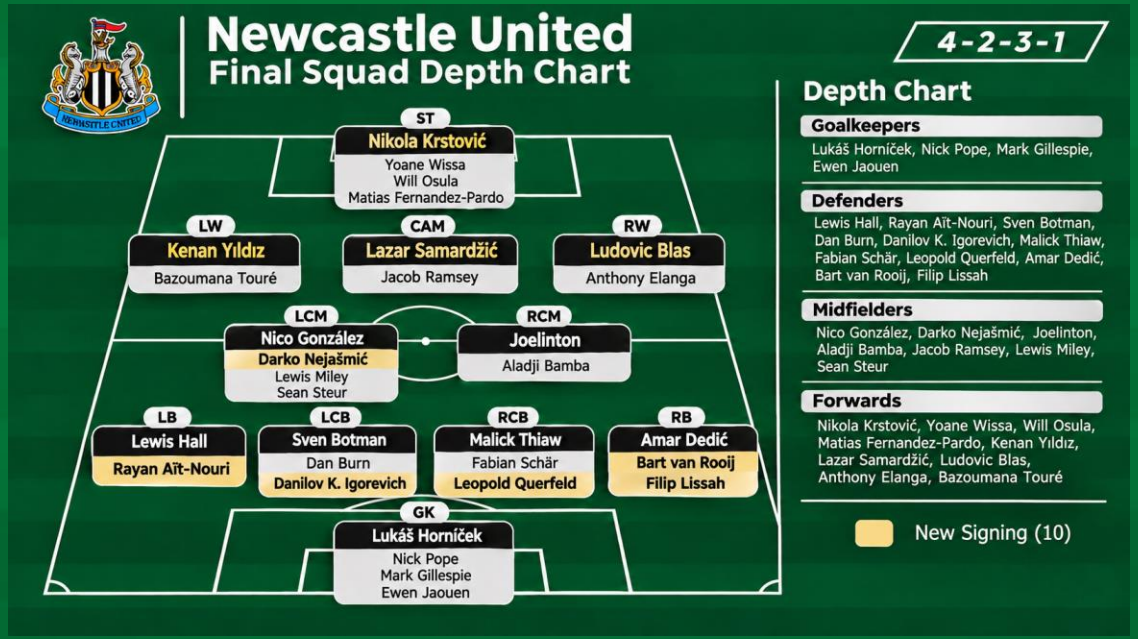


Incoming Players | −$224M

- Kenan Yıldız · $90M · LW/CAM
  - Elite attacking profile and long-term centerpiece
- Nikola Krstović · $33M · ST
  - Pressing striker profile to the vertical Striker role
- Rayan Aït-Nouri · $32.5M · LB
  - High model fit for the progressive wingback profile and provides strong first team depth for Lewis Hall
- Lazar Samardžić · $20M · CAM
  - Adds central creativity, progression, and final-third production
- Bart van Rooij · $13M · RB
  - Balanced two-way fullback with strong tactical fit
- Filip Lissah · $1M · RB/RCB
  - Low-cost depth with good defensive metrics at 21 years old
- Leopold Querfeld · $18M · RCB
  - Young CB with ideal progression and aerial profiling
- Ludovic Blas · $6M · RW/CAM
  - Bridge signing with strong creative output at significantly lower cost than alternatives
- Danilov Kirill Igorevich · $7.5M · LCB
  - Development signing with a strong model profile
- Darko Nejašmić · $3M · CDM
  - KNN-identified depth option with a Nico-like midfield profile

Final Squad & Finances

End Budget: $39.5M



Up the Magpies

